

Episode 123: Once Upon a Time... 71 – 1994 Part 5 – Zun Zun Jaka Jaka!

Tokyo is early summer. Day after day of clear skies with refreshing air continues, and beer tastes good (laugh).

Every year from this season through summer, I'm active from around 5 AM. Oh, not staying up all night—living by waking up at 4 or 5 AM. Yes, I've become a proper "morning person."

This early morning time period is quiet, the air feels good, and my head is clear, so thinking and work—whatever I do progresses efficiently and smoothly. It's a magic time period. This is wonderful. Waking up around this time, days can be used incredibly long without staying up late.

TV series-centered life progresses in weekly cycles with fixed schedules—like Wednesday for editing, Monday for dubbing and recording, Thursday for video editing to delivery. So this combination of "day-of-week based" daily life and being a "morning person" is strongest. They match very well.

But when it's the night before delivering episodes that are absolutely down to the wire, you can't say such things, and "morning person" becomes "until morning" work—that's troublesome.

Well, working hard like that for *The Tatami Galaxy*—last week was Episode 4 "Seeking Disciples" broadcast. And this week is Episode 5 "Softball Club 'Honwaka'" broadcast.

The production is already in the thick of the second half. Running toward the finale and DVD extras.

Thanks to everyone, ratings are gradually rising! This week too, please support us! Please look forward to it!!

Now then.

"Zun zun ja! Zun zun jaka jan! Zun zun jaka jaka!" Loudly lively music overflows from the radio. This is EEI-TOEI Studio's Second Studio, the trace room.

EEI-TOEI Studio was along a street called West Avenue in Quezon City. This area had a fairly leisurely residential feeling, and while West Avenue itself had reasonable traffic, along the street were scattered shops, restaurants, gas stations and such. This vicinity also had former US military residential areas.

Incidentally, at the north end of this West Avenue was a huge shopping market. This was "Shoe Mart." Huge building with huge parking lot. Complete with cinema complex and huge food court underground—a huge commercial facility.

The studio was divided into First and Second. About 100 metres apart along the same street, and while my memory is quite unreliable, I believe the Second Studio was larger and mainly for finishing work. Animation (in-between) and backgrounds were at the First Studio, I think. Hm? Which had the resident Japanese staff room? I think this was also at the Second. Guided by resident staff Soya-san and Tachisen-san, I toured the studio.

The work flow at EEI-TOEI Studio then was that luggage (key animation and in-between animation) collected at Tokyo Nerima's Oizumi Studio the previous day would arrive at Manila studio every evening. EEI-TOEI production staff would sort it. Key animation to in-between animation staff, completed in-between animation to finishing. Since background work was already being done in Manila, background-bound luggage was also carried to the background team. These were cross-referenced with invoices faxed from Tokyo in advance, with priority controlled according to schedule situations.

Since regular shipping would result in next-day arrival, business travellers from Tokyo like me arrive in Manila in half a day, so they happily load us up with massive hand-carried luggage.

So, completed in-between animation first gets packed into cut bags. These cut bags were Toei Animation specification, but the products themselves were Manila-made. Made by local companies here. Everything except special professional tools and dedicated equipment was locally Philippine-made. I think there were such laws? Cost-wise that was definitely better anyway.

After once confirming colour direction was applied through "inspection," they go to "machine trace."

Equipment was trace machines from Josai Duplo brought from Japan. These transferred in-between animation to cels via carbon transfer. Actually these trace machines often malfunctioned. Even with normal use in Tokyo, regular maintenance like glass tube cleaning and lamp replacement was necessary. Using them intensively in hot, humid Manila naturally led to frequent malfunctions and breakdowns, so manufacturer staff regularly travelled to Manila studio for maintenance. Incidentally, "raw cels" were Japanese-made. Sent from Tokyo by ship along with painting supplies and such.

After "machine trace" came "trace." Colour trace work for machine line corrections and shadow highlights. And this "Zun zun ja! Zun zun jaka jan! Zun zun jaka jaka!" room was the trace team's room.

About 10 staff were working in this noisy room. Most were male. Working so enjoyably while this radio blared was impressive. People chatting energetically while tracing, people quietly tracing in their own world. Japanese studios play radio during work too, but not at this incredible volume. Quite a light culture shock.

Next was "painting." The sight of painting desks with supply shelves lined up was the same here in Manila. Desks were naturally Manila-made. Not as much as trace, but here too everyone worked with reasonably loud radio music flowing. Many male staff here too. In Japanese domestic studios, finishing tends to center on female staff, but here males were vigorously painting.

"Painting" operated 24 hours with day and night shifts in two rotations. How many people were there? Even just the day shift had over 20 people, I think. Day and night shifts weren't fixed members but rotational shifts. Anyway, operating 24 hours meant continuous painting completion. Incidentally, trace and inspection had someone on night duty daily, but not full two-shift systems.

In principle, cuts worked on by day shift were finished by day shift and sent to inspection. So for work efficiency, cuts often involved multiple staff divisions. Few-frame cuts were painted by one person, but 40-50+ frame cuts were systematically approached by multiple people to ensure quick completion.

Painting's biggest bottleneck is "drying wait." It inevitably takes time for painted colours to properly dry. To ensure quick completion, everyone painting at once is the better method.

After painting came "inspection."

Oh, before that, cuts with brush or touch instructions went to "Special Effects" for work.

"Inspection" checked painted results, and checked cuts were packed daily after noon for Tokyo shipment. Since night shift painting completions were loaded first thing in the morning, mornings were quite busy.

About 10 "inspection" staff. Members carefully selected and promoted from painting staff. Naturally mostly women here. Each member handled assigned works, and they

handled Tokyo inquiries about unclear colour direction areas, local trace and painting questions, and coordination across multiple cuts and painting methods.

You can't do finishing inspection without properly understanding trace and painting. So it's promotion of excellent staff from painting. When establishing the Manila studio, those technical and systematic aspects were first properly considered and structured. While theatrical works get reinspected in Tokyo, for Toei Animation handling multiple TV production lines, cels from Manila studio had to reach levels where they could go directly to photography.

Thus shipped luggage would be delivered to Oizumi the next afternoon.

"Hi, Tsujita-san, ○△▼×◇●#### !"

Filipino staff were all impossibly cheerful, speaking to me with smiles. But I don't understand! (wry laugh) English would be manageable somehow, but local Tagalog was completely hopeless, so I could only respond with my best strained smile (wry laugh).

Rooms naturally had air conditioning, but unlike Tokyo's crisp air conditioning air, it was cold enough to be chilly yet somehow had lingering humidity. Outside was suddenly over 30 degrees, but indoors was cooled maximally by air conditioning. This was quite hard on me, but everyone here seemed fine. Their body construction is different after all.

Strangely, trace and painting teams wore fairly casual clothing. T-shirts and shorts, tank tops and jeans, some even shirtless in shorts. All of them wore white gloves while working. Those white gloves on somewhat dark Filipino skin were quite striking.

While individual, everyone seemed uniformly happy. I'd never seen people so happily doing trace, painting, and inspection in Japan.

Well, having toured the finishing department overall, various problems requiring improvement were visible everywhere. So now I had to talk to all staff about those problems.

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